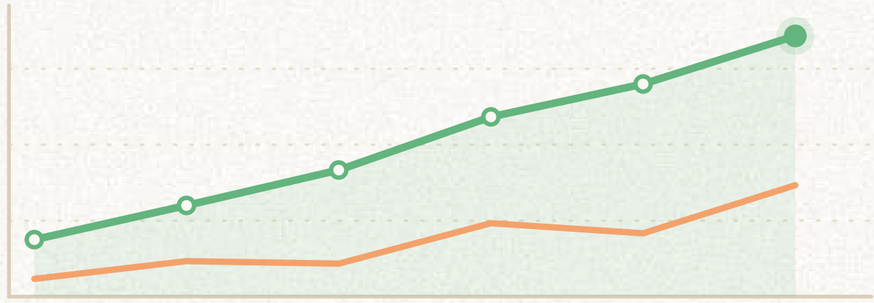
Lesson 2 · Writing

Vocabulary for trends.

ORANGE ENGLISH

The exact words examiners look for when data goes up, down, or nowhere at all.



WHY THIS MATTERS

One verb can be worth a whole band score.

Examiners reward **precise, varied language** . If every sentence says "went up" or "went down", your lexical resource score has a ceiling, no matter how accurate your data is.

in this lesson →

01 Describing an increase

02 Describing a decrease

03 Stability & fluctuation

04 Anchoring change in time

Describing an increase.

going up ↗

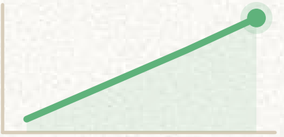
SLIGHT **rose slightly** · edged up · crept up

"Sales rose slightly in March."



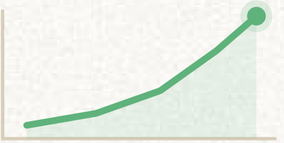
STEADY **increased steadily** · grew · climbed

"Profits grew steadily over the decade."



DRAMATIC **surged** · soared · rocketed

"Demand surged after 2018."

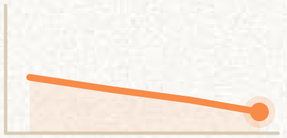


Describing a decrease.

going down ↘

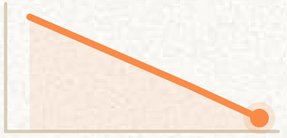
SLIGHT **dipped slightly** · eased back · edged down

"Prices eased slightly in Q2."



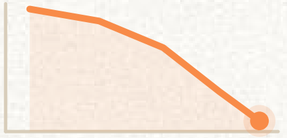
STEADY **declined steadily** · fell · dropped

"Membership fell steadily each year."



DRAMATIC **plummeted** · collapsed · nosedived

"Exports collapsed in 2020."



When the line doesn't go in one direction.

Stability

remained stable · levelled off · plateaued · stayed constant

"Numbers remained stable between 2015 and 2018."

Fluctuation

fluctuated · varied · rose and fell

"Prices fluctuated throughout the period."

a fluctuating trend



up, down, up, down, no clear direction

PART 3 · TIME EXPRESSIONS

Telling the examiner when it happened.

ORANGE ENGLISH

01
A single point

in 2010

at the start of the period

since 2020

02
A period

between 2010 and 2015

from 2010 to 2015

over the decade

03
An ongoing trend

throughout the period

over the course of the year

across the decade

04
Endpoint

by 2015

by the end of the period

by the final year

examiner mode

From band 5 to band 7, one sentence.

× WEAK

"The number of users went up a lot between 2010 and 2020."

vague verb, no precision

✓ STRONGER

"The number of users **rose dramatically** between 2010 and 2020., climbing from **2 million to 9 million**

varied verb + exact figures included

ACTIVITY your turn!

Sort the vocabulary.

Decide whether each word describes an increase, a decrease, or stability.

surged | plummeted | plateaued | climbed | fell | fluctuated | soared | declined | remained stable

↗ INCREASE	↘ DECREASE	→ STABILITY

ACTIVITY answer key

How the words sort out.

Three describe direction, two describe stability, and one fits none of them.

↗ INCREASE	↘ DECREASE	→ STABILITY
surged	plummeted	plateaued
climbed	fell	remained stable
soared	declined	

fluctuated the trick word, it describes **fluctuation** and belongs to none of the three.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

What to carry into your writing.

- **Vary your verbs**, don't repeat "went up / went down" for every graph.
- Match the adverb to the trend: **slightly, steadily,** or **dramatically**.
- Always **anchor the data in time**, using accurate time expressions.
- **Precision beats decoration**, one well-chosen verb outperforms a long sentence.

next up →

Grammar for Data Description